



TRACES

12-STATEMENT SCREENER

January 2026



Trauma and Relational Adversity in Caregiver Environments (TRACEs) Screener

A Rapid Screener for Trauma Activation in Multi-Systemic Caregiving

Welcome to the TRACEs Screener—a tool developed to support parents and caregivers navigating the complex, emotionally demanding role of raising youth involved in multiple systems. The Screener is designed to identify signs of caregiver strain, systemic overwhelm, and trauma activation, helping teams respond with meaningful, compassionate, and coordinated support.

Purpose of the Screener

The TRACEs Screener offers a focused lens on the invisible burdens carried by caregivers of multi-system-involved youth. By highlighting patterns of relational stress, system fatigue, and emotional depletion, the Screener helps providers, peer supporters, and care teams understand when a caregiver may need stabilization, collaborative planning, or deeper conversation.

Structure of the Screener

The Screener is structured around six trauma-responsive domains that impact caregiver well-being:

- Parent-to-Child Impact
- Spousal/Nuclear Family Impact
- Extended Family Impact
- Social/Community Impact (School, Medical Provider Offices, Places of Worship, etc.)
- Financial Strain
- Household Safety

Using the Screener

The Screener is intended as a starting point—a way to open space for honest dialogue and caregiver-centered planning. It may be used at intake, during care team meetings, or in reflective peer support conversations. Rather than dictating eligibility for services, the number of “Yes” responses helps guide the type and urgency of next steps. These may include team-based planning, coordination of services, clinical integration, or safety supports; depending on what the caregiver wants and needs.

If the caregiver identifies significant distress or the presence of safety concerns, the full TRACEs Assessment may be offered to deepen understanding and guide more tailored intervention strategies.

Trauma and Relational Adversity in Caregiver Environments (TRACES) – Screener

General Family Information

Parent/Caregiver Name:

Youth Name:

Phone Number:

Email Address:

Caregiver Type (Circle One): Biological Parent Foster/Kinship Placement Adoptive Other

Youth Age Group (Circle One): 0-7 Early Childhood 8-13 Youth 14-18 Transitional

Does your child have a disability (Circle One): Yes No

Which Systems of Care is your family currently involved with?

- ☐ Juvenile Justice
- ☐ Child Welfare
- ☐ Disability Support Services
- ☐ Complex Medical Needs
- ☐ School Disciplinary/Truancy
- ☐ Mental/Behavioral Health
- ☐ Interdisciplinary Wraparound Care
- ☐ Adult Justice
- ☐ Individualized Education Plan (IEP or 504 Plan)

Trauma and Relational Adversity in Caregiver Environments (TRACeS) – Screener

TRACeS Screener

Do you agree that the following statements accurately reflect your present situation?

(PCI) I find it challenging to understand and respond to my child's needs.	Not Applicable	Yes	No
(PCI) I struggle to manage my child's challenging behaviors effectively.	Not Applicable	Yes	No
(S/NFI) Conflicts due to parenting disagreements frequently arise in our family.	Not Applicable	Yes	No
(S/NFI) Changes and challenges disrupt our family routines significantly.	Not Applicable	Yes	No
(EFI) Involvement with extended family often leads to more stress rather than well-being.	Not Applicable	Yes	No
(EFI) Extended family lacks understanding and acceptance of my child's needs.	Not Applicable	Yes	No
(S/CI) I often feel isolated from my community due to my child's needs or behaviors.	Not Applicable	Yes	No
(S/CI) Advocating for my child's needs in social and community settings is overwhelming.	Not Applicable	Yes	No
(FS) Caring for my child's needs places a significant financial burden on our family.	Not Applicable	Yes	No
(FS) I have had to make difficult career or job changes due to my child's needs.	Not Applicable	Yes	No
(HS) Our home lacks necessary equipment or modifications for my child's safety needs.	Not Applicable	Yes	No
(HS) My child threatens or is physically violent with me or others in my home.	Not Applicable	Yes	No

Total: _____

Screener Scoring Rubric

Do you agree that the following statements accurately reflect your present situation?

# of “Yes” Responses	TRACEs Activation Level	Interpretation	Suggested Next Steps
0–2	<i>Stable with Strain</i>	Minor or localized challenges. No clear trauma activation.	Validate experience, offer self-guided tools (e.g. workbook, grounding guide), monitor over time. Optionally offer wellness check-in later.
3–5	<i>Systemic Tension</i>	Early signs of stress accumulation. Patterns may be forming across domains.	Open dialogue about specific pain points. Normalize help-seeking. Invite caregiver to co-develop a lightweight care map or community support plan.
6–9	<i>Trauma Activation Present</i>	Relational, financial, and/or systemic trauma is likely affecting caregiver functioning.	Facilitate a reflective conversation about what has felt most overwhelming. Begin care plan or team huddle. Consider cross-system convening (school, case management, respite navigation). Offer grounding practices or journaling from TRACEs workbook.
10–12	<i>Crisis Embedded in Care</i>	Signs of moral injury, deep fatigue, or household instability. May include safety concerns.	Escalate care planning. Flag for multidisciplinary case review. Collaborate with the caregiver on a dignity-centered plan. Include clinical, respite, housing/safety, and community wraparound options as needed. Ensure provider continuity and prevent re-traumatization.

Safety Flag Protocol (Overrides Score)

If either safety-related item (e.g., "Our home lacks necessary equipment" or "My child threatens or is physically violent") is marked Yes, initiate:

- Immediate conversation with the caregiver
- A safety planning conversation (if non-crisis), or
- A warm connection to clinical team, housing navigator, or crisis protocol (if risk is active)
- Facilitators don't have to “fix it”; just open the path safely, and document the flag clearly.